



COMEBACK PLATFORM: Bhutto's supporters vouch for their leader

also likely to lead to street protests from his party.

In the worst case, a deteriorating political situation may actually cause the army to step in and ask Musharraf to step down. There is precedent for such an action, in the case of 'Field Marshal' President Ayub Khan, who was asked to step aside in 1969 to make way for General Yahya Khan after civil unrest all over Pakistan and the growing insurgency in then East Pakistan. In such a drastic situation, the army high command may decide that Musharraf's person is a liability they would be better off without. A new general at the top would also not be bound by Musharraf's promises—made to stem persistent domestic rumours and international jitters—not to impose martial law or an emergency.

Most insiders do not see any indication of such a worst-case scenario

Should the deal with Bhutto not work out, Musharraf may even be pushed out of power by the army. ★

Foreign Relations Committee during Bhutto's earlier stint in power, she too has been averse to accepting an arrangement with any religious party this time round, another sign of American influence in the Musharraf-Bhutto deal brokering.

In fact, Bhutto has indicated that the stumbling blocks in her talks with Musharraf have been primarily his political allies "who support the Talibanisation of Pakistan", a sarcastic reference to Shujaat who had also advocated negotiations with the Lal Masjid extremists. Should the deal with Bhutto not work out, however, for whatever reason, Musharraf will be left with very few options. One possible scenario could be to dissolve the assemblies immediately and order early elections. While that may buy Musharraf a little more time as President—at least until a new electoral college is established—and also temper the opposition against his standing for re-election as president from the current parliament, it is a strategy fraught with uncertainties. There is no guarantee then for Musharraf being able to win re-election.

Sharif's arrival on the scene with-

out a deal in place is also likely to cause much unrest in the current charged atmosphere. Having gone into exile in Saudi Arabia under a purported deal to escape a 10-year jail-term for "hijacking" and endangering a commercial flight on which Musharraf was travelling back to Pakistan—the incident that triggered the army coup against him—he had been marginalised from Pakistani politics for the last seven-and-a-half years. But the lawyers' agitation against Musharraf changed ground realities and he found the resolve to announce a date once the Supreme Court dismissed the Government's pleas of a deal as irrelevant to Sharif's fundamental rights. The Government's options in dealing with him are limited by the Supreme Court's direction that he not be prevented from returning to Pakistan. In the most likely scenario, if Sharif does live up to his promise of returning—and despite reported Saudi Government pleas for him to honour his agreement, it is now a political necessity for him to return—he would most likely be thrown into jail to serve out the conviction to circumvent which he had agreed to go into exile in Saudi Arabia. However, such a scenario is

unfolding at the present time. But it is also true that questions are already being raised about the morale within the armed forces after some 300 soldiers were captured by militants in South Waziristan without a shot being fired. The involvement of the Pakistan Army in the fight against alleged Al Qaeda and Taliban militants on the Pakistan side of the Afghan border has exacted a heavy toll and is increasingly being seen as Musharraf's fight at the behest of the US. The latest bombings, on September 4 near army GHQ in Rawalpindi, particularly of an unmarked bus carrying Inter-Services Intelligence personnel, has further shaken the confidence of the armed forces. In a dire political situation, it is not inconceivable that Musharraf loses the confidence of his army colleagues.

Beyond his commando training, Musharraf also referred in *In the Line of Fire* to his sense of being blessed because of his many narrow escapes from death, both during his military duty and the assassination attempts on him as President. If General Musharraf manages to emerge intact from his current predicament, he could well consider it another very lucky escape from political death. ■